



This book will only discuss personal firewalls, which are software applications made for end-users. A personal firewall will not usually protect any more than the one PC it is installed on, unless other PCs are sharing Internet connectivity via the protected PC. There are many misconceptions about firewalls; most people misunderstand what a firewall does for you. Here's a little explanation to clear things up.

What Can A Firewall Do?

Generally, firewalls are configured to protect against unauthenticated logins from the 'outside world'. This, more than anything, helps prevent vandals from logging into machines on your network. More elaborate firewalls block traffic coming into a PC, but allow outgoing traffic. Firewalls can also provide a single 'choke point'—in a situation where a computer system is being attacked by someone dialling in with a modem, a firewall can act as an effective 'phone tap' and tracing tool. Firewalls provide an important logging and auditing function—they provide summaries about the amount and different types of traffic that have passed through it, how many attempts were made to break in, and so on.

What Can't A Firewall Do?

Firewalls can't protect you against attacks that come through software that your firewall isn't protecting. For instance, when you install the firewall and then run a P2P software, the firewall asks whether you want it to monitor that software. More often than not, we disable monitoring of software because we want as little interference as possible. Now if there are security holes in the P2P